CHAPTER XII

The Quiet Inventory

Kolkata · March–December 2024

“Before leaving, we discover how much an ordinary room has kept for us: unfinished work, small proofs of effort, objects whose importance would be difficult to explain. We sort them slowly, finding that usefulness is not always what makes something worth carrying. A page may preserve an afternoon; a familiar voice may remain within a sentence. And among the things we cannot take, there are some we no longer need to ask the world to return.”

On the morning of 12 March, Utkarsh reached for the notebook he had brought home the day before. The page was still open where the lesson had ended. He closed it before putting it in his bag.

Kolkata was already warm when Utkarsh reached the coaching centre. The streets were familiar, the shops were opening, and the occasional sound of a passing motorcycle rose above the conversations of people beginning their day. He climbed the stairs with his notebook in one hand, passing the same walls and the same noticeboard he had passed countless times before.

Nothing about the building suggested that it had witnessed anything important.

Inside, the classroom was gradually filling. A few students were discussing a question from the previous day’s lesson. Someone had borrowed a pen and was making an unnecessarily elaborate promise to return it. Near the front, two boys were arguing over an answer neither seemed particularly certain about.

Utkarsh took his usual seat.

Until yesterday, entering this room had meant looking for one particular person before doing anything else. Sometimes he had

done it so instinctively that he noticed only afterward. He would glance towards the door, pretend to arrange his books, and find some insignificant reason to remain attentive to the sound of approaching footsteps.

That morning, he opened his notebook. When footsteps paused outside, he looked up before he could stop himself. It was another student. He bent over the page again, irritated by how little his body seemed to know of what he had understood yesterday.

A calculation from the previous class remained unfinished. He looked at it for a while, found the mistake, and began again.

Sanondita arrived a little later.

He noticed her when she passed his desk. They exchanged a greeting, and she settled into her usual place. For a moment, he considered asking whether she was feeling better. The question remained with him long enough for him to look in her direction, but she had already opened her notebook.

He returned to his calculation.

He wanted to know whether she had slept, whether the morning had been any easier. But asking would mean bringing yesterday back between them, and she had given him no sign that she wanted to speak about it. He kept the question to himself. The calculation took him three attempts.

Bikash Sir arrived carrying a few loose sheets and placed them on the desk.

The lesson began as it always did.

For the better part of an hour, there were sentences on the board, hurried corrections, and the familiar interruption of students asking him to explain a rule again. Utkarsh put his calculation aside and worked through the English exercises. Once, he corrected a sentence only to discover that he had introduced a second mistake. Bikash Sir appeared to regard this as a valuable contribution to the lesson.

Then, between two questions, Bikash Sir mentioned that the timing of the classes would have to change.

The morning batch would be shifted to the evening.

At first, it sounded like another ordinary adjustment, the sort of inconvenience students complained about before eventually accepting. A few people asked questions. Someone wanted to know whether the change was permanent. Another wondered if the earlier arrangement could continue for a little longer.

Utkarsh looked towards Sanondita.

He knew the evening would be difficult for her.

And before he had properly considered what the announcement meant, he found himself preparing to object.

There were still things about that classroom he had taken for granted.

The announcement had put an end to none of them yet. He was already trying to hold them in place.

“Sir, is it necessary to change the timing?”

Utkarsh had spoken before the discussion could settle.

Bikash Sir looked up from the papers on his desk. “What happened? You have some problem with the evening?”

“Not just me, sir. Some of us might have other things to do.”

“Then tell me which timing would be suitable for everyone.”

A few students offered suggestions, none particularly helpful. Someone proposed moving the class an hour earlier. Another wanted to know whether the morning batch could continue on alternate days. Bikash Sir listened, occasionally shaking his head, until the suggestions began repeating themselves.

Utkarsh glanced towards Sanondita.

She had been listening quietly. He knew that she had responsibilities outside coaching, including the students she taught herself. He also knew that changing an established routine was not as simple for her as it might be for someone with an otherwise empty afternoon.

He turned back towards the front.

“Sir, why don’t we continue in the morning? Most of us have already adjusted our schedules.”

“Most of you?” Bikash Sir repeated. “Then ask everyone.”

It was not quite the support Utkarsh had hoped for, but he accepted the challenge.

He turned to the others.

“Who wants to continue with the morning timing?”

A few hands rose. Someone nodded without raising a hand. Two students exchanged a look, apparently waiting to see which answer would be more convenient.

“And the rest of you?”

One boy shrugged. “Evening is fine.”

“Morning is better,” Utkarsh said.

“For you,” the boy replied.

There was nothing particularly hostile in the exchange. The boy had simply stated his preference, just as Utkarsh had stated his. Nevertheless, Utkarsh found himself irritated by how easily the matter could be decided by people who seemed to have so little invested in it.

He tried again, asking those seated farther back. One student said he could manage either timing. Another preferred the evening because he would no longer have to hurry in the morning.

The small collection of objections he had hoped to gather never became anything substantial.

Bikash Sir waited until the discussion had exhausted itself.

“See? Everyone has different preferences. I cannot arrange the class separately for each person.”

“But sir—”

“Utkarsh, I understand. If there is some difficulty, you can speak to me afterward. For now, this is the arrangement.”

The matter was settled with the casual finality of an ordinary administrative decision.

Utkarsh sat back.

He could have continued arguing. There were other arrangements he might have suggested, although he was no longer sure he could explain his insistence without looking towards her

again. But he had already made his position clear, and Bikash Sir was preparing to resume the lesson.

Beside him, a page turned.

He looked towards Sanondita.

“Will you be able to come in the evening?”

She considered the question for a moment.

“I don’t think so.”

He waited, although there was no particular reason to expect her answer to change.

“My students,” she added. “It’ll be difficult.”

He nodded.

There was nothing surprising about her response. He had anticipated it almost from the moment Bikash Sir made the announcement. Still, hearing it spoken aloud left him with the peculiar frustration of having failed to prevent something he had known was coming.

“Maybe sir will change his mind,” he said.

“Maybe.”

The word was offered without much conviction.

Bikash Sir called for everyone’s attention, and Utkarsh turned towards the board.

The next sentence was already being written.

For the remainder of the class, he tried to concentrate. Occasionally, someone whispered about the new schedule. A few students were already discussing how they would manage the evenings. The matter had begun to settle into the ordinary business of adjustment.

When the lesson ended, notebooks closed, chairs scraped against the floor, and conversations resumed around the room.

Utkarsh gathered his things. He could have stayed to discuss the timetable with Bikash Sir, but he could not see how a separate request would restore the morning batch. He would try preparing at home. There were enough unfinished portions of the syllabus to

make use of the hours he usually spent travelling, and he wanted to find out how much he could manage on his own.

He and Sanondita exchanged a few ordinary words before leaving. There was no particular reason to prolong the conversation. They had known each other long enough that another meeting did not require arranging in advance.

Outside, the day continued as it always had.

The shops were open. Traffic moved along the road. Somewhere nearby, a vendor was calling to passing customers.

Utkarsh went home expecting that there would be another opportunity to see her.

He did not look back at the entrance. There was nothing yet to distinguish it from all the other days on which they had left separately.

For several days afterward, Utkarsh continued to think of the coaching centre in the present tense.

It was an easy habit to maintain. He had spent so many months arranging his mornings around those classes that the new schedule still seemed temporary, something Bikash Sir might reconsider after a few complaints. Even when the usual hour arrived and he remained in his room, he occasionally found himself glancing at the clock, calculating how far the lesson would have progressed by then.

The first few mornings felt like unexpected holidays. There was no need to hurry through breakfast, gather his notebooks, or leave early enough to account for Kolkata’s unpredictable traffic. He could begin studying whenever he wished, without losing time travelling to and from the coaching centre.

By the end of the week, the convenience had begun to feel less remarkable.

His books were still there. The syllabus remained unchanged. There were enough unfinished chapters and practice questions to occupy him for months. Yet something about the arrangement of

his days had shifted, and he could not quite decide whether the difference was welcome.

Once, while searching through his notebook for a formula, he came across a page on which Sanondita had written a calculation.

He recognised her handwriting before remembering the question.

For a few moments, he examined the working, trying to recall why they had disagreed over the answer. There had been some small mistake, perhaps in the final step. He could remember her insisting that her method was correct and himself attempting to prove otherwise, but not which of them had eventually been right.

He turned the page.

On the next page, his own working looked less orderly than hers. He began the exercise again, then caught himself framing an objection she was no longer there to hear. For a moment he let the pen rest. The answer, when he reached it, gave him nobody to argue with.

Over the following weeks, he began to recognise what the classroom had supplied without either of them having to ask. Some mornings he still remembered a joke he might have told her. Occasionally, a difficult question reminded him of the arguments they used to have over solutions. And whenever he passed a familiar stretch of road, he could almost anticipate the sight of someone walking beside him.

Some days he returned to work quickly. On others, the smallest recollection left him reading the same question long after he had understood it. Gradually, there were more of the first kind.

Their conversations continued on WhatsApp, although there was less to say.

Without the coaching centre, the ordinary incidents that had once supplied their conversations began to disappear. There were no classmates to complain about, no unexpected remarks from a teacher, no amusing mistakes to revisit after returning home. Their messages gradually became concerned with examinations,

application forms, registration dates, and the occasional question about preparation.

One afternoon, Sanondita asked whether he had completed a particular registration.

He replied that he had.

She wanted to know whether a document needed to be uploaded again.

He checked the instructions and answered her.

A few more messages followed, and then the conversation ended.

Utkarsh placed the phone beside his notebook and returned to studying.

It was a perfectly ordinary exchange. She had asked something, he had helped, and neither had needed to invent another subject merely to keep talking.

He did not think much of it until later, when he noticed how long it had been since they had last spoken about anything unrelated to an examination.

He almost sent her a message about the question he was working on. She would probably recognise the mistake; she had pointed out the same one often enough. He typed the first few words, then stopped. He had already corrected it.

For a while, he left the unfinished message on the screen. When he deleted it, he felt the small loss of a conversation that would have been easy to begin in a classroom.

He reached for his pen.

Outside, the afternoon had begun to darken beneath gathering clouds. Somewhere in the building, a television was playing loudly enough for him to hear fragments of a conversation. A motorcycle passed along the street, followed by the impatient sound of a horn.

His friends still had places to go and things to tell him. Some evenings he joined them; increasingly, he stayed at his desk. A short errand seemed manageable. An afternoon without his books was harder to allow himself.

By late May, almost a year had passed since college. The examination he had appeared for in 2023 had felt, in retrospect, like something he could afford to attempt without placing his entire future upon the result. This year was different.

On his phone, photographs from new offices appeared between examination updates. Someone he knew had bought a motorcycle. He looked at the picture, then at the question paper waiting beneath his hand. He had intended to finish it before lunch.

He turned the phone facedown and pulled the paper towards him.

The first problem was easier than he had expected.

He solved it, checked the answer, and moved to the next.

By evening, the rain had begun.

He heard it against the window without getting up to look.

There had been another rainy day, months earlier, when he had wished a walk would last a little longer.

This time, he was hoping the electricity would remain on until he finished the paper.

June arrived with the sort of heat that made even the evenings reluctant to cool.

By then, Utkarsh had grown accustomed to spending most of his days indoors. The morning hours belonged to mathematics and reasoning, the afternoons to English and general awareness, and the evenings to whatever remained unfinished. Some days went according to plan. On others, he spent an unreasonable amount of time on questions he should have solved easily, only to discover that the hour had passed and he had accomplished very little.

He had begun measuring his days in questions attempted, mistakes corrected, and chapters revised.

It was not a particularly interesting way to live.

But interest had become a luxury he could postpone.

One afternoon, his phone vibrated beside a stack of practice papers.

Sanondita had sent him a message.

Why don’t we go somewhere? It’s been so long since we’ve met.

Utkarsh read it twice.

For a moment, the room seemed considerably less tiresome.

He had not expected an invitation. Their conversations had become so infrequent, and so firmly attached to examinations, that the possibility of meeting her had gradually retreated into something he thought about without attempting to arrange.

Now she was asking.

He looked at the message again, wondering where she wanted to go. Perhaps she had grown tired of remaining occupied with her own responsibilities. Perhaps she simply missed the company they had once enjoyed in class.

He was still considering what to reply when another message appeared.

Ujjawal keeps asking me to go out with him. I don't want to go alone, and I don't want to keep refusing him either. So I thought you could come with us.

Utkarsh read the second message.

Then he read the first again.

Nothing in its wording had changed. Yet the invitation that had seemed so pleasant a moment earlier now belonged to an entirely different afternoon.

He set the phone down.

He knew Ujjawal had been interested in Sanondita for a long time. There had been enough conversations, enough small indications, for Utkarsh to understand what those invitations probably meant to him. He also knew that Sanondita was uncomfortable accepting them alone.

She had asked him because she trusted him to accompany her.

There was nothing unreasonable about that.

Still, he could not imagine sitting across a restaurant table while Ujjawal attempted to make the afternoon memorable, and Sanondita tried to keep the conversation comfortable. He knew only what she had asked of him; the rest was an afternoon he was already imagining, and did not want to attend.

He picked up the phone.

No.

He sent the message before reconsidering it.

For a while, he watched the screen. He had not supplied an excuse about studying, an unfinished assignment, or some imaginary obligation. There was no elaborate explanation waiting to follow.

He simply did not want to go.

He returned the phone to the desk.

The practice paper remained open at the same question. He read it, found that he had forgotten what he was calculating, and began again.

The interruption had lasted only a few minutes.

A year earlier, he might have spent the remainder of the afternoon wondering how to turn such an invitation into an opportunity. He might have accepted an arrangement he disliked merely because it offered another hour in her company.

Now he had refused. He did not feel pleased with himself. Part of him still wanted to retrieve those few seconds in which the invitation had seemed to be simply hers. But he left his answer as it was and worked through the question.

When he finished, he checked the answer before reaching for his phone.

On 22 June, Sanondita went to Barbeque Nation with Ujjawal.

Utkarsh did not accompany them.

The day passed without any particular incident in his room. He studied, ate, returned to his desk, and occasionally checked his phone when it vibrated. Whatever happened over lunch belonged to the two people who had gone.

He did not ask how it went.

There was a time when he would have wanted to know every detail.

By evening, he had finished considerably more work than he had expected.

Two days later, at three minutes past midnight, his phone lit up again.

Happy birthday, Utkarsh!

He was awake when the message arrived.

For several weeks, Sanondita had been asking when his birthday was. The questions had appeared at unexpected moments, sometimes in the middle of conversations that had nothing to do with birthdays.

He had refused to tell her at first.

It was not a date he usually advertised. He had never made much effort to announce it on social media, and he preferred the quiet convenience of allowing the day to pass without too many people remembering.

Sanondita, however, had seemed unusually certain that it was approaching.

Is it in June?

He remembered looking at that question with some surprise.

How had she known the month?

Perhaps he had mentioned it during a conversation at coaching and forgotten. Perhaps someone else had spoken about birthdays, and she had remembered something he had said without thinking. There were several possible explanations, none important enough to investigate and yet curious enough to remain with him.

Eventually, he had told her the date.

And now, at 12:03 a.m., she had remembered it.

He read her message, and a small, involuntary happiness passed through him.

There was something pleasant about being remembered by someone who had taken the trouble to ask.

He thanked her.

For a little while, he remained awake, looking through the messages that had arrived from other people. Before placing the phone aside, he opened hers once more. It contained nothing he had

missed the first time. She had remembered. Tonight, he could be glad of that without asking the message to mean anything else.

He had once waited until two minutes past midnight to wish her on her birthday. He remembered that evening, the anticipation, the gift he had chosen, and the note he had placed with it. She had thanked him after returning home. Whether she had read anything into the note beyond the words themselves was something he had never learned.

He did not try to settle the question now.

His desk was covered with books. The next day's work was already waiting.

He switched off the light.

Outside, Kolkata was still awake in fragments: a distant vehicle, the occasional bark of a dog, voices rising briefly from the street before disappearing again.

For the first time in several years, his birthday felt less like an occasion to celebrate growing older than a reminder of how quickly time was passing.

He would have preferred to think about that in the morning.

But sleep did not come immediately.

By July, the room had begun to acquire the untidy permanence of a place where someone spent too much of his life.

Books occupied nearly every available surface. Previous years' question papers were stacked beside the desk, their corners curling in the humidity. A notebook lay open beneath another, and somewhere among the loose sheets was a list of topics Utkarsh had intended to revise three days earlier.

The ceiling fan turned above him with a sound he had stopped noticing.

At eight in the morning, he was solving mathematics. By noon, he had moved to reasoning. English occupied part of the afternoon, followed by general awareness, which seemed to grow larger every time he attempted to measure how much remained.

Some days he completed everything he had planned.

On others, a single question could spoil an entire hour.

He would arrive at an answer, check the solution, discover a mistake, and begin again. Occasionally, the second attempt produced a different wrong answer, which was somehow more irritating than the first.

“Wonderful,” he muttered one afternoon, staring at his notebook. “At least I’m consistent in being inconsistent.”

There was nobody to appreciate the remark.

He crossed out the calculation and started over.

A year earlier, he had been finishing college and attempting his first examination. Now there were people from those classrooms earning salaries, making plans for further study, discussing what they would do next with an ease he envied.

Utkarsh was still preparing.

It was an ordinary enough word, preparing. It suggested movement, discipline, the patient approach towards something worthwhile.

But on certain afternoons, when the same walls had surrounded him since morning and the same unfinished syllabus waited on his desk, he found it difficult to distinguish preparation from standing still.

He had not forgotten why he was there.

A government job meant stability. It meant having an income of his own, making plans that did not depend entirely on somebody else’s circumstances, and finally being able to answer questions about his future without beginning every sentence with if.

There were days when the thought was enough to carry him through another practice paper.

There were others when it was precisely what made the paper difficult to finish.

The heat remained oppressive well into August. Rain brought relief for an hour and left the room damp afterward. His clothes took longer to dry. The pages of his notebooks softened at the edges. Sometimes the electricity failed in the middle of an online

mock test, and he sat looking at the disconnected screen as though irritation alone might restore the connection.

He began going outside less often.

At first, it was a practical decision. Travelling somewhere meant losing time. Meeting someone for an hour rarely remained an hour. A short walk could be postponed until the evening, and by evening there was usually something unfinished.

Eventually, leaving the room began to require more effort than remaining inside it.

He still went out for necessities. He bought food, collected whatever he needed, and occasionally walked farther than necessary simply because the air indoors had become unbearable. But most days passed between his desk, his bed, and the small collection of ordinary objects that had come to define his life in Kolkata.

He stopped keeping track of how many evenings he had spent without speaking to anyone in person.

The silence was not always unpleasant.

Sometimes he welcomed it. Nobody interrupted his calculations. Nobody asked how preparation was going. Nobody offered the familiar reassurance that he would surely succeed this time, a kindness that had begun to feel uncomfortably like another expectation.

At other times, the room seemed to grow smaller as the evening advanced.

He would finish studying, put down his pen, and discover that he had no particular desire to do anything else.

There were films he could have watched, people he could have called, places he could have visited. He considered these possibilities with the vague interest of someone examining a menu after losing his appetite.

Then he would pick up his phone, scroll for a few minutes, and put it down again.

Sleep became less dependable.

Some nights he remained awake long after the lights in neighbouring rooms had gone out. His mind moved from an unfinished question to an approaching deadline, from the examination to the possibility of another year passing in much the same way. He tried sleeping earlier, then later, then returning to his usual schedule.

There were nights when he took melatonin, hoping it would help him sleep.

Even then, he sometimes found himself awake, listening to the fan and calculating how many hours remained before morning.

Once, at nearly two, he reached for his phone and opened WhatsApp.

Several conversations were waiting exactly where he had left them.

Sanondita's name appeared among them.

Their most recent exchange concerned an examination registration. He had answered her question, and she had thanked him. Nothing remained unanswered.

He looked at the conversation for a moment, then locked the screen.

There was no particular reason to message her.

He lay back and stared into the darkness.

Months earlier, he might have invented one.

The thought came and went without disturbing him as much as he might once have expected.

In the morning, he woke later than intended.

For several minutes he remained in bed, aware of the sunlight entering through the curtains and the work he had already begun to lose time for. His head felt heavy. The thought of another day at the desk was exhausting before the day had properly begun.

Eventually, he got up.

He washed his face, made something to eat, and sat down with the previous day's unfinished questions.

The first page contained several mistakes.

He examined them one by one.

By afternoon, he had corrected most of them.

There was no satisfaction dramatic enough to transform the day. No sudden confidence, no certainty that the examination would reward his efforts, no reassuring sense that everything was finally falling into place.

There was only a little less work remaining than there had been that morning.

For the time being, he accepted that.

As August moved towards September, the examination ceased to feel like a distant event for which he was preparing and became something approaching him whether he was ready or not.

He revised topics he knew well and discovered mistakes he had not expected to make. He attempted mock tests under timed conditions. On some days, his scores improved enough to encourage him. On others, the numbers seemed determined to remind him how uncertain the outcome remained.

He began checking the calendar more frequently.

September was almost here.

And somewhere beyond the examination, beyond the answer key and the result he could not yet imagine, December waited.

He had already made a decision about that month.

If he qualified for Tier-II, he would remain in Kolkata and continue preparing.

If he did not, he would leave.

He had not chosen a departure date. There was no ticket, no packed suitcase, no final arrangement to make.

But the decision existed.

Occasionally, when he thought about leaving, he remembered that there was still someone he wanted to meet before he went.

The thought of meeting her had stayed with him since the classes ended. He had not wanted the next meeting to be a goodbye; now the possibility of leaving gave the wish a deadline he could not yet name.

There was an examination to get through first.

He turned to the next page of his notebook, checked the time, and began another set of questions.

September arrived without bringing the relief Utkarsh had imagined it might.

For months, he had thought of the examination as a distant point towards which everything was moving. Now that it was close enough to count the remaining days, he found himself wishing for another week. Not because he had been careless with his preparation, but because every subject seemed to contain a few questions he could still get wrong.

He had stopped trying to complete the syllabus in the way he once understood completion. There was always another fact to remember, another method that might save twenty seconds, another question whose answer appeared obvious only after he had made the mistake.

His desk had become an arrangement of priorities. Mathematics occupied one side, reasoning the other. English notes lay beneath a collection of previous years' papers, while general awareness had spread into so many notebooks that he occasionally spent longer searching for a particular topic than revising it.

One evening, he attempted a mock test and performed considerably worse than he had expected.

He sat looking at the score.

Several questions had been straightforward. He had recognised the methods, understood what was being asked, and still arrived at the wrong answers. In reasoning, he had spent too much time reconsidering a question he had initially solved correctly. In mathematics, an unnecessary calculation had cost him the time he needed for another problem.

He opened the analysis.

For nearly an hour, he went through the mistakes, marking those caused by carelessness separately from those he genuinely did not know.

The distinction offered little comfort.

A wrong answer remained a wrong answer, whatever explanation he attached to it.

He closed the laptop and went to the window.

Below, the street was busy with people who appeared to know exactly where they were going. A delivery rider stopped near a shop. Two men stood beside a motorcycle, discussing something with great seriousness. A car moved slowly through the traffic, its windows closed against the evening heat.

Utkarsh watched until the car disappeared.

He had begun to dislike how quickly he noticed a car or a motorcycle and made it evidence against himself. He knew nothing about the people who owned them. That knowledge did not stop him watching the road a little longer before returning to his desk.

He returned to his desk, intending to revise the questions he had missed, but found himself looking instead at the calendar.

A few more days.

He had spent so much time imagining the consequences of the examination that he sometimes forgot the paper would be over before he had lived through another day of waiting for it.

The days immediately before it passed in an uneasy alternation of confidence and doubt. A good practice session could persuade him that he was ready. A careless mistake could undo the reassurance before lunch. He checked the details of his examination centre more than once, arranged the documents he needed, and set aside the things he would carry.

On the morning of the examination, he woke before his alarm.

For a moment, lying in the dimness, he could not remember why he felt so alert.

Then he remembered.

He got out of bed.

Kolkata was already beginning its day when he left. The roads were familiar in the way roads become familiar after months of travelling through them, though the journey felt different now. He

checked the time repeatedly, despite having allowed himself more than enough of it.

At the examination centre, candidates gathered near the entrance in small, restless groups. Some were discussing questions they hoped would appear. Others were revising facts from their phones. A few stood silently, looking towards the building as though it might offer some indication of what awaited them.

Utkarsh found a place away from the conversations.

He had never understood the usefulness of revising an entire subject in the final ten minutes. Yet he could feel the temptation to take out his phone and search for something he might have forgotten.

He resisted it.

A boy standing nearby was explaining a shortcut to his friend. Halfway through the explanation, he contradicted himself, laughed, and began again.

Utkarsh almost smiled.

Months of preparation, and everyone was still trying to find one more thing to know.

When the candidates were allowed inside, the waiting gave way to a succession of ordinary instructions. Documents were checked. Seats were assigned. The room filled with the subdued movements of people settling themselves before something important.

Utkarsh sat down and looked at the screen.

For a brief moment, he thought of his room: the desk, the curling question papers, the evenings spent correcting mistakes nobody else would ever see.

Then the examination began.

The first few questions passed quickly. He recognised familiar patterns and worked through them with the concentration that sometimes arrived only when there was no longer time to worry about concentration itself.

A question in mathematics required more calculation than he had anticipated. He left it and moved on.

Another appeared easier until he reached the final step.

He checked the options, returned to his working, and corrected an error.

Time continued moving.

There were questions he knew immediately, questions he could solve with patience, and others whose answers remained uncertain despite his best efforts. Occasionally, he felt the familiar urge to spend another minute on something simply because he had already spent two.

He forced himself to move forward.

At one point, he glanced at the remaining time and realised that the examination was progressing faster than it had seemed.

He adjusted his pace.

By the final minutes, the screen had become a collection of decisions already made and a few he could still reconsider. He returned to one question, read it again, and decided not to change his answer.

He had changed correct answers into wrong ones often enough during practice.

When the examination ended, he remained seated for a moment, looking at the screen that no longer required anything from him.

There was no immediate sense of triumph.

Nor was there the certainty of failure he had sometimes feared.

He had answered what he could. Some questions had gone well. Others had not. The result existed somewhere within those answers, but he had no way of knowing what it would be.

Outside, the candidates began comparing their attempts almost as soon as they left the building.

“How many?”

“Was mathematics difficult?”

“What did you get for that reasoning question?”

Someone announced a number of attempts that made several others turn towards him.

Utkarsh listened briefly before walking away.

He had never found these conversations particularly reassuring. A high number of attempts could mean confidence, accuracy, recklessness, or some combination of all three. And hearing somebody else's answer to a question he could no longer change seemed an unnecessary way to spoil the journey home.

He took out his phone.

There were messages waiting.

One was from Sanondita, asking how the examination had gone.

He stood near the roadside and considered his reply.

It was okay. Not sure about the result.

She replied that she hoped it would go well.

He thanked her.

For a moment, he considered telling her about the question he had almost solved, or the candidate who had been confidently explaining a shortcut outside the centre. Both would once have been perfectly adequate beginnings for a longer conversation.

Instead, he put the phone away.

He was tired. The story about the candidate could wait, though he knew how often a story lost its occasion that way.

There would be other things to discuss when there were other things to say.

On the journey home, the city looked much as it had that morning. Traffic gathered at the same crossings. Shops remained open. People moved along the pavements with bags, umbrellas, and the unremarkable concerns of an ordinary day.

He had spent months preparing for something that had now ended.

Yet the future it was supposed to decide remained exactly where it had been: beyond his reach.

That evening, he did not study.

He ate, washed, and sat near the window for a while, listening to the sounds rising from the street. He considered watching a film but could not settle on one. He opened a book, read half a page, and closed it.

Eventually, he went to bed.

For the first time in weeks, there was no mock test he needed to attempt before sleeping.

He had expected the freedom to feel larger.

Instead, he found himself wondering what he was supposed to do with tomorrow.

The answer came easily enough.

He would begin preparing for the next stage.

He did not yet know whether he would be allowed to sit for it.

But waiting without doing anything seemed worse.

On the third of October, the answer key was released.

Utkarsh learned about it from a notification on his phone.

For a few moments, he continued looking at the question he had been solving. He had known the answer key was expected, had checked for updates more often than he cared to admit, and had spent the preceding days wondering whether the examination had gone as well as he hoped. Yet now that the answers were available, he felt strangely reluctant to see them.

There was something comfortable about uncertainty when the alternative might be disappointment.

He finished the calculation, closed his notebook, and opened the examination website.

The page took longer to load than usual.

He refreshed it once, then again. After entering the necessary details, he waited while the screen remained almost entirely white, apart from a small symbol indicating that something was happening.

“Of course,” he muttered. “Take your time.”

When the answer key finally appeared, he leaned closer.

At first, the process was mechanical. He compared the recorded responses with the official answers, moving through the questions one by one. Some were correct, just as he had expected. Others were wrong in ways he immediately understood. There were also a

few he had been certain about during the examination and could now see he had answered incorrectly.

Those were the most irritating.

He paused over a mathematics question, worked through it again on a loose sheet, and found the error within seconds.

It was such a small mistake that he almost wished the question had been difficult.

He continued.

By the time he finished checking, he had a score.

He looked at the number for a while.

It was not disastrous. There were marks he could reasonably be pleased with, questions he had answered correctly under pressure, and sections in which his preparation had served him well. But the score was not high enough to free him from doubt.

Qualification depended on more than his own performance. There would be cutoffs, competition, and the distribution of marks across different examination shifts. The number on his screen was real; what it meant for his future was not yet settled.

He checked his calculations again.

Then he checked the expected cutoffs being discussed online.

One estimate suggested he might qualify. Another placed the likely threshold a little higher. A third offered several possibilities, accompanied by so many conditions that the prediction seemed designed to avoid being wrong regardless of the eventual result.

He closed the page.

Ten minutes later, he opened another.

By evening, he had read enough predictions to feel less certain than he had before.

He wrote his score in a notebook and put a line beneath it.

There was nothing else he could calculate that would change the answers he had given in September.

For the next few days, he tried to return to his routine.

The syllabus for Tier-II was waiting. He knew that if he qualified, the time between the two stages would become

important. Every day spent hesitating would be a day he could not recover later.

So he studied.

Not with the same intensity that had carried him through August and September, but enough to keep the subjects familiar. He revised mathematics, attempted reasoning questions, and returned to English passages he had once completed more confidently.

Some afternoons went well.

On others, he found himself reading the same paragraph repeatedly while thinking about the result.

He could not decide whether he was preparing for an opportunity or postponing the acceptance of a disappointment.

The distinction began to matter less as the weeks passed.

He still had questions to solve.

October moved on, and Kolkata began changing around him.

There were preparations for Durga Puja, lights being arranged across streets, temporary structures rising where there had recently been ordinary stretches of road, and crowds gathering in places that had been comparatively quiet only weeks earlier.

Utkarsh noticed these things mostly when he went out to buy something.

The city had always possessed an extraordinary ability to make celebration feel unavoidable. Music travelled between buildings. Traffic slowed near crowded intersections. Even familiar roads appeared altered beneath decorations that would disappear after a few days.

At one crossing, he remembered standing among the previous year’s crowds, checking his phone. This year he could put it away and look at the lights. He went out occasionally and stayed until he grew tired, though sometimes he returned sooner than he had intended. From his room, the music sounded almost as close. He could hear the celebration without having to decide how to join it.

One evening, standing near a roadside tea stall, he watched a group of young men laughing over something on a phone. One of

them was wearing an office identification card that swung against his shirt whenever he moved.

Utkarsh noticed the card before he noticed the laughter.

He looked away almost immediately.

It was becoming an unpleasant habit, this tendency to discover evidence of other people's progress in the most ordinary details of their lives.

He finished his tea and returned home.

His mother called that night.

She asked how he was doing, whether he was eating properly, and whether there had been any news about the examination.

"Not yet," he said.

"And your preparation?"

"Going on."

"Properly?"

He looked towards the open notebook on his desk.

"Yes."

She seemed satisfied enough to move on to other things.

They spoke for a while longer. There were familiar questions about food, the weather, and whether he needed anything. He answered them as he usually did, occasionally offering more reassurance than he possessed.

After the call ended, he remained seated with the phone in his hand.

He had not lied exactly.

He was preparing.

But there were differences between working and working well, between spending six hours at a desk and knowing what those six hours had accomplished. He had begun to recognise those differences with an accuracy he sometimes wished he lacked.

He opened his notebook.

A question remained unfinished from the afternoon.

He completed it before going to bed.

November arrived.

The days grew shorter, though Kolkata had not yet acquired the cold that would come later. His mornings were quieter now. He no longer rushed to begin studying the moment he woke. Sometimes he allowed himself an extra half-hour before sitting down, telling himself that the examination result might still be weeks away.

The reasoning was convenient.

He knew it was convenient.

Yet uncertainty had a way of making discipline feel negotiable.

There were days when he worked steadily and evenings when he accomplished almost nothing. He sometimes looked at the calendar and counted the weeks remaining in the year, then stopped because the exercise offered no useful answer.

His conversations with Sanondita continued occasionally.

A question about an examination. A registration date. Some detail neither of them was entirely certain about.

The exchanges were courteous, familiar, and brief.

He had begun to understand how much of their earlier closeness had belonged to the circumstances in which they met. There had been a classroom, shared lessons, common journeys, and the effortless availability of another conversation the following morning.

Without those things, friendship required a different kind of attention.

Neither of them seemed particularly skilled at supplying it from a distance.

He did not blame her for that.

He was hardly making much effort himself.

One evening, he opened their conversation to check a registration date and found that the information was several messages farther back than he expected. They had spoken more often than he remembered. Yet he could read the whole exchange without finding anything he wished to continue.

He copied the date into his notebook. He had stopped inventing reasons to speak, but he had not learned how to say that he missed speaking without one.

December was approaching, and he still did not know whether he would be staying in Kolkata.

He had begun thinking about what he would need to take with him if he left.

There were books he would certainly carry, others he could leave behind, clothes that had accumulated in corners, and ordinary possessions whose importance would become apparent only when he began packing.

He had not packed anything.

He had not even decided what to do with the things he would not need.

But sometimes, while looking around the room, he found himself considering it as a place he might soon have to describe in the past tense.

Then he would remember the alternative.

If he qualified, the room would remain his. The desk would remain crowded, the notebooks unfinished, and the next examination would give him another reason to stay.

He could live with that.

He wanted to.

On the evening of the fourth of December, he attempted a few questions and stopped earlier than usual.

He knew the result could arrive soon.

There was no particular reason to expect that the following day would be different from the many days he had already spent waiting.

Still, before going to bed, he checked the official website once more.

Nothing had changed.

He closed the page and switched off the light.

In the darkness, the room was familiar down to its smallest sounds: the fan, the occasional vehicle outside, the faint movement of air near the window.

He had spent so much of the year trying to secure a future in this city.

He left the laptop beside the bed. If the result appeared in the morning, he would not have to look for it.

On the fifth of December, Utkarsh woke to the sound of his phone vibrating against the desk.

He reached for it without opening his eyes completely.

There were messages in one of the examination groups. Several had arrived within the same minute, followed by more as he struggled to make sense of the conversation.

Result out.

Check the official website.

Cutoff is higher than expected.

He sat up.

For a moment, he remained motionless, looking at the screen. Then he pushed aside the blanket and reached for his laptop.

The website was slow.

He had expected it to be. Thousands of candidates would be attempting to access the same information, each hoping to find a particular sequence of numbers among thousands of others. He waited through an error message, refreshed the page, and tried again.

When the result document finally opened, he searched for his roll number.

Nothing appeared.

He checked the digits.

He searched again.

Still nothing.

There was an uncomfortable simplicity to the process. A year’s preparation, months of calculations, and weeks of uncertainty had been reduced to a search bar and an absence.

He opened the cutoff notice.

The figures were there, arranged neatly in rows and columns. He found the relevant category, compared the threshold with his marks, and looked at the difference.

A few marks.

He calculated it again, although there was no possibility that the subtraction would produce a more favourable answer the second time.

Then he returned to the result document and searched once more.

The number was not there.

He closed the document.

For a while, he sat looking at the desktop.

He rested his hand on the notebook beside the laptop. It was open to the work he had planned for that morning. His thumb held the page down although there was no breeze to turn it.

After a while, he moved his hand. He was tired, and the day had scarcely begun.

He had known this outcome was possible. Since October, he had carried the possibility through every practice session, every prediction he had read, and every conversation in which someone asked whether he expected to qualify.

Knowing that disappointment might come, however, had done remarkably little to prepare him for its arrival.

He leaned back in his chair.

A few marks.

The phrase was almost insulting in its smallness.

He thought of the mathematics question he had solved incorrectly despite knowing the method. He remembered changing an answer during a mock test and promising himself not to repeat the mistake. He thought of the questions he had left unanswered because time had run out.

It would have been easy to assemble a different examination from those memories—one in which he had avoided two mistakes, solved one more problem, and reached the necessary score.

He began doing exactly that.

Then he stopped.

There was no use constructing a version of September that had never happened.

The marks were what they were.

He looked around the room.

The desk was crowded with books for the next stage of an examination he would not be taking. A notebook lay open to a page of questions he had intended to finish that afternoon. Beside it was a pen whose ink had begun to fade, although he had continued using it because it still worked if he pressed hard enough.

Nothing in the room had changed.

That was perhaps the strangest part.

The same objects remained in their places, indifferent to the fact that the purpose for which he had arranged so much of his life had suddenly disappeared.

His phone vibrated again.

Candidates were discussing the cutoff. Some were celebrating. Others were comparing their marks with the qualifying threshold, discovering that they had missed it by two, three, or five marks. A few were already arguing about whether the examination had been fair.

Utkarsh read several messages before putting the phone facedown.

He had no desire to compare disappointments.

After a while, he got up and made himself something to eat.

He was not particularly hungry, but he had eaten very little the previous evening. He stood near the kitchen counter, waiting for the food to be ready, and found himself looking at the clock.

It was still morning.

He had expected a day like this to feel longer.

Instead, time continued moving with an almost offensive indifference.

He ate, washed the plate, and returned to his room.

His mother called sometime later.

He had considered calling her first, but the thought of saying the words aloud had made him postpone it. Now, seeing her name on the screen, he answered.

“Have the results come?”

“Yes.”

There was a brief pause.

“What happened?”

“I didn’t qualify.”

He heard movement at the other end, as though she had shifted the phone or sat down.

“By how much?”

“A few marks.”

“Oh.”

It was a small sound, carrying disappointment without quite knowing where to place it.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then she asked whether he was certain.

“Yes. I checked.”

“You worked hard.”

He looked towards the desk.

“I know.”

The answer came out more sharply than he intended. He looked at the fading ink on the open page and pressed his lips together. He wanted her to know how hard he had worked. He could not bear being told, just then, that she already did.

There were things she might have said about trying again, about how one examination did not determine everything, about how there would be other opportunities. He had heard those things before, and he knew they were reasonable.

But she did not begin with any of them.

“Have you eaten?”

“Yes.”

“Properly?”

He glanced towards the plate he had just washed.

“Yes.”

“Then don’t sit there thinking about it all day.”

He almost told her that he had very little else to do.

Instead, he said, “Okay.”

They spoke for a few more minutes. She asked when he would come home, and he told her he would decide soon.

After the call, he remained standing beside the desk. She had asked whether he had eaten in almost the same voice she used on ordinary days. He had managed to answer until then. Now he looked towards the washed plate and stayed where he was.

He had already made that decision months earlier.

If he qualified for Tier-II, he would stay in Kolkata.

If he failed, he would leave.

At the time, the arrangement had seemed practical, almost reassuring. There would be no need to deliberate indefinitely. The examination would determine which course he followed.

Now the condition had been fulfilled, and he discovered that knowing what he had decided was not quite the same as being ready to carry it out.

He sat down and opened a drawer.

Inside were old receipts, spare pens, a few photographs, and papers he had kept for reasons he could no longer remember. Beneath them lay a notebook from his earliest months in Kolkata.

He opened it.

The handwriting was neater than he expected.

On one page, he had written a list of topics to complete before his first examination. Several had been crossed out. Others remained untouched, their importance long since overtaken by newer lists and different deadlines.

He turned another page.

There were notes from coaching, calculations written hurriedly during class, and a date in March 2023.

Beside the date was a calculation he had written before he knew Sanondita's name. He could still remember the classroom in which he had copied it, the people who sat near him, how readily he had expected to see them again. The page had survived all those changes without acquiring any sign of them.

He closed the notebook.

The room was quiet.

For a long time, he had imagined leaving this room because he had somewhere better to go: a posting, a job, a life he could describe without first explaining an examination. Now he would be carrying the same books home.

He would go on preparing. He knew that. What troubled him was how clearly he could remember the person who had unpacked those books, and how much that person had expected of him.

Towards evening, he began sorting the books on his desk.

He separated the ones he would take from those he could leave behind. Some were still useful; others contained material he could find again whenever he needed it. He gathered loose papers into a folder and discovered how many notes he had accumulated without ever looking at them twice.

The work was ordinary enough to occupy his hands.

Occasionally, he stopped to examine something he had forgotten.

A receipt from a bookshop. An old examination admit card. A page torn from a notebook, covered in calculations whose original question he could no longer identify.

He put them aside one by one.

At the bottom of a stack, he found a sheet from the coaching centre.

For a moment, he held it between his fingers.

He remembered Bikash Sir standing at the front of the classroom, announcing the change in timing. He remembered objecting, turning towards his classmates, and discovering how little support he could gather. He remembered Sanondita saying that the evening would be difficult for her.

They had left that day expecting there would be other days.

There had been no more classes together.

He placed the sheet with the papers he intended to keep.

His phone lay on the bed. He looked towards it. Before leaving, he still wanted to meet Sanondita.

The result had made his departure certain, but he did not want to speak to her while the disappointment was fresh enough to enter everything he said. There were arrangements he could begin without needing to explain himself.

He folded the coaching sheet and placed it inside the notebook. Outside, the December air had begun to cool. He returned to sorting his books.

In the days that followed, Utkarsh discovered that leaving a city required considerably more decisions than arriving in one.

When he had first come to Kolkata, he had brought what he thought he would need and trusted the rest to circumstance. Now, nearly two years later, there were things he could not remember buying, papers whose importance had expired, and books he had carried between shelves without opening for months. Every drawer seemed to contain some evidence of a day he had otherwise forgotten.

He began with the easiest things.

Old receipts went into the wastebasket. Loose notes were sorted into folders. He set aside the clothes he would need until his departure and folded the rest into a suitcase that had spent most of the year beneath his bed.

The books were more difficult.

Some had cost him enough that he hesitated to leave them behind. Others were full of corrections, pencilled shortcuts, and small improvements he had made over months of practice. He opened one at random and found a problem he had once struggled to solve. The method seemed obvious now.

He worked through it in the margin, almost without thinking.

The answer was correct.

He looked at the page for another moment before closing the book.

There had been a time when getting such a question right would have pleased him for the rest of the afternoon. Now it was simply something he knew how to do.

The book would be useful at home. He lifted the folded clothes and placed it beneath them.

For several days, the room remained caught between its familiar disorder and the unfamiliar neatness of departure. There were fewer books on the desk, but the empty spaces made the remaining ones look strangely misplaced. The shelf beside his bed gradually cleared. A corner that had been occupied by old newspapers and examination materials became visible for the first time in months.

He continued studying occasionally.

There would be other examinations, other attempts, and more work to do when he returned home. The result had changed where he would prepare, not the necessity of preparing. Some mornings he still woke with the impulse to begin a mock test before breakfast, only to remember that the urgency which had governed the past few months was no longer quite the same.

He did not always resist the impulse.

Once, after spending most of the morning packing, he sat down to solve a set of reasoning questions. He had intended to attempt ten. By the time he looked at the clock, he had completed thirty.

He was surprised to discover that he had enjoyed himself.

There was something reassuring about a problem whose answer could be established without waiting for a committee, a cutoff, or the performance of thousands of strangers.

He marked the last question and put the notebook away.

That afternoon, he went outside.

The December air was cooler than it had been only a few weeks earlier. People walked along the pavements in light sweaters, and the roadside tea stalls had begun attracting customers who lingered over their cups. The traffic was no less impatient, the shopkeepers

no less occupied, and the city seemed entirely unconcerned with the approaching end of his time there.

He walked without deciding where he would turn.

For much of the year, he had treated every journey outside as time borrowed from preparation. Even a short errand had been accompanied by the knowledge that something remained unfinished at home. Now, with his books partly packed and his immediate plans unsettled, he found that he could spend an afternoon walking without needing to justify it.

He passed a stationery shop where he had once purchased notebooks, a crossing at which he had waited through countless changes of the traffic lights, and a row of shops whose signs he knew well enough to recognise from a distance.

He remembered the first months after arriving in Kolkata, when even ordinary streets had seemed to promise discoveries.

Somewhere along those early journeys, he had learned a girl's name from Tanisha.

The memory returned without warning.

He could still recall how pleased he had been by so little. A name had given shape to a curiosity he had not known what to do with. Later there had been conversations, arguments over questions, afternoons spent walking, and the gradual accumulation of details that had made Sanondita less a person he wondered about than someone whose company had become familiar.

He remembered the amusement of discovering that she already knew his name before they had properly introduced themselves.

He never did find out how.

Perhaps she had heard someone call him during class. Perhaps the explanation was so ordinary that neither of them had thought it worth mentioning.

He passed the crossing and continued walking.

There were things about people that remained unknown even after months of friendship. Sometimes the questions were

important. Sometimes they had mattered only because of the person to whom they belonged.

He had once wanted to know everything.

Now, when he thought of Sanondita, it was often some small, unremarkable detail that returned first: the way she defended an answer she believed was correct, the particular impatience with which she reacted to a difficult question, or a conversation that had become funny for reasons neither of them could have explained afterward.

He could remember these things without needing anything to follow them.

At a tea stall, he stopped and ordered a cup.

The man serving him was speaking to another customer about the rising price of something. Utkarsh listened without paying much attention. When his tea arrived, he moved aside to make room for the next person.

A motorcycle stopped near the pavement.

The rider removed his helmet, took out his phone, and began speaking to someone. He sounded pleased about something, although Utkarsh could not make out the conversation.

For a moment, Utkarsh thought of the photographs he had spent months looking at: motorcycles, cars, offices, journeys, all the ordinary announcements of lives that seemed to be progressing while his remained uncertain.

He took another sip of tea.

The man finished his call and rode away.

Utkarsh watched him disappear into traffic, then turned back towards the stall.

He still wanted those things. He wanted work, an income, the freedom to make decisions without calculating their cost, and the satisfaction of having built something dependable for himself.

He wanted them no less because he had failed an examination.

But for once, another person’s motorcycle remained merely a motorcycle.

He finished his tea and paid.

By the time he returned to his room, evening had begun gathering around the buildings.

He switched on the light and resumed packing.

His phone vibrated while he was folding a shirt.

A message had arrived in one of the examination groups. Someone was discussing the next recruitment cycle, asking whether the syllabus was likely to change.

Utkarsh read the message and set the phone aside.

There would be time for that conversation.

He folded the shirt and placed it with the others.

He left a little room at one end of the suitcase for the notebook he was still using. He would pack it last. For now, it lay open on the desk, beside a pen that needed replacing.

That evening, his mother called again to ask about his arrangements.

He told her that he had begun packing.

“When are you coming?”

“Soon. I’ll tell you when I’ve decided.”

“Don’t leave everything until the last day.”

“I won’t.”

She sounded unconvinced.

He promised to call when he had settled the details.

Afterward, he looked around the room.

The suitcase stood beside the bed, not yet closed. A few books remained on the desk. His notebook lay open where he had left it, with a pen resting across the page.

There was enough work left to occupy another day.

He sat down and wrote a short list of things he needed to finish before leaving.

At the bottom, after the practical arrangements, he left a little space.

He had been thinking about meeting Sanondita since the day their coaching classes had effectively ended. At first, he had

imagined the conversation in several different ways. There had been words he wanted to say, explanations he thought he owed to the feelings he had carried for so long, and moments when he wondered whether speaking would make any difference.

Months had passed.

The conversation had changed in his mind, although he had not noticed exactly when.

He no longer imagined it leading somewhere.

He could not picture himself asking her for a place in her life that she had never offered, or treating an account of his feelings as something she must answer.

Whatever he might say would belong to the past.

The future, uncertain as it remained, had begun to demand his attention elsewhere.

He picked up his pen.

For a moment, he considered writing her name at the bottom of the list.

Then he put the pen down.

A meeting was not an errand to be completed between returning a borrowed book and purchasing a train ticket.

He tore the page from the notebook and placed it beside the suitcase.

The room had grown quiet.

He could hear someone walking along the corridor, a door closing farther away, and the faint sound of traffic beyond the window.

He opened his phone.

Their conversation was where he had left it, among messages about examinations, registration dates, and the occasional exchange that had required no particular reason. He scrolled upward for a little while, passing older conversations whose circumstances he remembered more clearly than their words.

He stopped at a message that made him laugh.

It was something absurd she had said months earlier, during one of their arguments over a question. He read it again. For a moment he wanted to answer as though the intervening months were only the pause before his reply.

The empty space beneath the messages waited. He could ask when she was free. The words were ordinary; what made him hesitate was knowing that this time he would have to choose a day, go to meet her, and come home to a suitcase.

He locked the screen and placed the phone on the desk.

He stood and went to the window.

Kolkata stretched beyond the buildings in scattered lights. Somewhere in the distance, a train sounded its horn. He could not see it from where he stood, but he listened until the sound faded.

He thought of the city he had arrived in, the examination he had failed, the people he had met, and the ordinary days that had become important without announcing themselves.

He would remember much of it.

He would miss some of it.

And there were parts he was ready to leave behind.

On the desk, his phone remained silent.

Utkarsh turned away from the window and returned to his suitcase.

He still had a few things to pack.